and more convinced the manager was going to leave me out for the second leg. I talked to some mates about it. They all said the same thing:

‘No chance. You’ll play. It doesn’t matter what’s gone on, you’ll play.’

In the couple of days leading up to the Madrid game, I did my best to concentrate on our preparations like everyone else, but the thought that I was going to be dropped just nagged away at me like a sore tooth. Gary and I always used to joke that we’d learned how to tell—from how the boss was behaving towards us—if he was getting a shock ready for us.

‘He was nice to me yesterday. So he’s going to leave me out of the team tomorrow.’

That instinct, after so many years working with him, told me that the boss’s manner leading up to the Wednesday night was all wrong as far as my chances were concerned. No harsh words no little digs: it was as if I wasn’t even there. Out at training on the morning of the game, the manager pulled me to one side. He just said what he had to say, and what I knew he was going to say:

‘David, you’re not going to start tonight. You’ll be on the bench.’

I flinched. Although I’d been expecting it, to hear the boss say that was like being hit between the shoulder blades. It suddenly felt as if the whole of the season had been about him building up to doing this to me. I was on the outside looking in. *Real Madrid: an important game, son. Too important for you to play in.* I could taste the anger and the disappointment in the back of my throat. Sometimes, your feelings are so confused and so complicated you’re frozen to the spot. I looked at the manager, tried to look into his eyes: nothing there for me. I shook my head, turned round, and began walking back to the dressing room.

‘David. Come back here. Don’t walkaway from me.’

The boss didn’t shout. He didn’t lose his temper. It was as if he was asking me, not telling me, *David, please come back. I want to finish what I was saying.*

As if there was anything that needed to be said. I just kept walking. Thinking back to that scene now, I’d say that if the manager had still cared about me as a person or as a player, we’d have had an argument there and then. He wouldn’t have let me walkaway from him like that.